

Grade 6 reference book

Figured bass, the chords of a key, progressions, the part-writing checklist, cadences, notes outside the chord, modulation, devices, the orchestra, composing and terms.

1. FIGURED BASS: WHAT THE FIGURES MEAN

Count up from the bass in letter names, inside the key signature. A dash after a figure means hold that note into the next chord.

Figure	Short for	Chord position	Example in C (bass → chord)
(none)	5/3	root position (a)	C → C-E-G
6	6/3	first inversion (b)	E → C-E-G
6/4	6/4	second inversion (c)	G → C-E-G
7	7/5/3	7th chord, root position	G → G-B-D-F
6/5	6/5/3	7th chord, first inversion	B → G-B-D-F
4/3	6/4/3	7th chord, second inversion	D → G-B-D-F
4/2 (or 2)	6/4/2	7th chord, third inversion	F → G-B-D-F
# or ♯ alone	raised 3rd	the 3rd above the bass is raised	in A minor, E with # → E-G#-B
#6, ♯6 ...	raised 6th	that note is raised	in A minor, B with #6 → G# above

2. THE CHORDS OF A KEY

In minor, use the harmonic minor for chords: V and VII have the raised leading note. II is diminished in minor, so use IIb. VIIb is a diminished chord used in first inversion (like V7 without its root). III is rarely used at Grade 6.

	C major	quality	A minor (harmonic)	quality
I	C-E-G	major	A-C-E	minor
II	D-F-A	minor	B-D-F	diminished
III	E-G-B	minor	C-E-G#	augmented
IV	F-A-C	major	D-F-A	minor
V	G-B-D	major	E-G#-B	major
VI	A-C-E	minor	F-A-C	major
VII	B-D-F	diminished	G#-B-D	diminished

3. PROGRESSIONS TO KNOW BY HEART

Models made by the app's harmony engine: complete chords, smooth parts, no consecutive 5ths or octaves.

I IV Ic V I

Cadential 6/4: Ic-V-I (C major)

I VI II7b V7 I

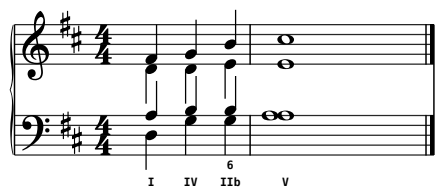
II7b - V7 - I (G major)

I Vc Ib IV V I

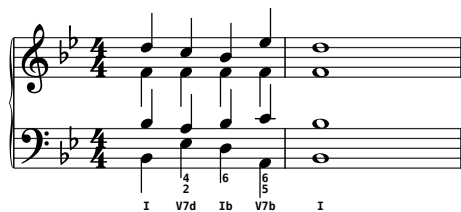
Passing 6/4: I - Vc - Ib (F major)

I IV V VI

Interrupted cadence V - VI (A minor)



Imperfect cadence: IIb - V (D major)



V7 inversions resolving (B major)

WHICH CHORD COMES NEXT?

Avoid V → IV. Strong root movements: up a 4th or down a 5th (V-I, II-V, VI-II).

From	Good next chords
I	any chord: IV, II, V, VI, Ib ...
Ib	IV, II, V
II, IIb, II7b	V, V7 or Ic (then V)
IV	V, Ic, II, I
V, V7	I, or VI (interrupted)
VI	IV, II, V
VIIb	I or Ib
Ic	V or V7 over the same bass (cadential 6/4)

4. THE PART-WRITING CHECKLIST

- Every chord complete: root and 3rd always; 5th may go in root-position V7 or a final I.
- Doubling: double the root in root position; in a 6/4 double the bass; in first inversion double the root or 5th (IIb: double the bass). Never double the leading note or a 7th.
- Ranges: soprano C4-G5, alto G3-D5, tenor C3-G4, bass E2-D4. Keep soprano-alto and alto-tenor within an octave.
- No parts crossing or overlapping.
- No consecutive 5ths or octaves between any pair of parts (check all six pairs). No hidden octaves in the outer parts on a leap.
- The leading note rises to the tonic (in an inner part at a cadence it may fall to the 5th).
- The 7th of a 7th chord falls by step.
- In minor: write the raised leading note's accidental every time; avoid the augmented 2nd (6th to raised 7th) in a part.
- 6/4 chords only as cadential (Ic-V), passing (I-Vc-Ib) or auxiliary/pedal (I-IVc-I).
- Keep common notes in the same part; move other parts to the nearest note.

5. CADENCES

Cadence	Chords	Notes
Perfect	V-I or V7-I (both root position)	Ic-V-I is the strongest; melody 2-1 or 7-8
Imperfect	I, Ib, II, IIb, IV or Ic → V	ends on V: sounds unfinished
Plagal	IV-I	the 'Amen' cadence
Interrupted	V-VI	the surprise; in minor double the 3rd of VI

6. NOTES OUTSIDE THE CHORD

x marks the note outside the chord. Passing and auxiliary notes are usually off the beat; appoggiaturas and suspensions fall on the beat.



Passing note: steps between two chord notes



Auxiliary note: steps away and back



Appoggiatura: a clash ON the beat, often leapt to, resolving by step



Suspension: held over, clashes, falls by step (4-3, 7-6, 9-8)



Anticipation: the next chord's note, sounded early



Changing notes: step above and below (or below and above), then the chord note

7. RELATED KEYS AND MODULATION

A major key most often modulates to its dominant (new sharp or lost flat: the raised 4th). A minor key most often goes to its relative major (the raised 7th is cancelled). A pivot chord belongs to both keys: in C → G, A minor is VI in C and II in G.

Key	Relative minor	Dominant	Subdominant
C major	A minor	G major (and E minor)	F major (and D minor)
G major	E minor	D major (and B minor)	C major (and A minor)
D major	B minor	A major (and F# minor)	G major (and E minor)
A major	F# minor	E major (and C# minor)	D major (and B minor)
E major	C# minor	B major (and G# minor)	A major (and F# minor)
F major	D minor	C major (and A minor)	Bb major (and G minor)
Bb major	G minor	F major (and D minor)	Eb major (and C minor)
Eb major	C minor	Bb major (and G minor)	Ab major (and F minor)
Ab major	F minor	Eb major (and C minor)	Db major (and Bb minor)

8. MUSICAL DEVICES

Device	What to look for
rising sequence	The same shape is repeated, starting a step higher each time.
falling sequence	The same shape is repeated, starting a step lower each time.
imitation	One part plays a phrase, then another part copies it while the first carries on.
inversion	The second phrase turns the first upside down: where it went up, it now goes down by the same steps.
augmentation	The second phrase repeats the first with the note values doubled.
syncopation	The accents fall off the beat: notes start between beats and are held across them.
tonic pedal	The bass holds (or repeats) the tonic while the harmony above changes.
dominant pedal	The bass holds (or repeats) the dominant while the harmony above changes.
Alberti bass	The left hand breaks each chord into the pattern low-high-middle-high.
hemiola	In 3/4, two bars are grouped as if they were three bars of 2/4: three minims across two bars, usually just before a cadence.
ostinato	A short pattern is repeated over and over in the bass.
repetition	The phrase is repeated exactly.

9. THE ORCHESTRA

String terms: arco, pizzicato, con sordino, sul ponticello, divisi, tremolo, double stopping. Brass/wind: tongued, a 2 (both players), 1. (first player only).

Family (score order)	Instruments, top to bottom	Clef	Sounds
Woodwind	piccolo	treble	an octave higher than written
	flute, oboe	treble	as written
	cor anglais	treble	a 5th lower
	clarinet in Bb / A	treble	a major 2nd / minor 3rd lower
	bassoon	bass (tenor high)	as written

Family (score order)	Instruments, top to bottom	Clef	Sounds
Brass	horn in F	treble (often no key signature)	a 5th lower
	trumpet in B $\flat$	treble	a major 2nd lower
	trombone	tenor or bass	as written
	tuba	bass	as written
Percussion	timpani	bass	as written
Strings	violin I, violin II	treble	as written
	viola	alto	as written
	cello	bass (tenor high)	as written
	double bass	bass	an octave lower

10. COMPOSING A MELODY: THE EXAMINER'S CHECKLIST

Plan before writing: bars 1–4 end on an imperfect cadence (degree 2, 5 or 7); bars 5–8 modulate and come back; the last bar ends on the tonic. Sing it in your head as you write.

1. 8 bars, and every bar adds up to the time signature
2. Two balanced phrases, with a clear cadence at bar 4
3. The opening's rhythm or shape comes back (repeat, sequence or a variation)
4. It modulates clearly (a new accidental, or in a minor key cancelling the raised 7th to reach the relative major) and comes back home
5. A clear high point, and a good shape: mostly steps with some leaps
6. It ends on the tonic, on a strong beat
7. It stays in the instrument's range and suits the instrument
8. A tempo marking (an Italian term is fine)
9. Dynamics, including at least one change
10. Phrasing slurs and some articulation (staccato, accents, tenuto)

11. TERMS

Grade 1

allegro: fast, lively

andante: at a walking pace

adagio: slow

moderato: at a moderate speed

allegretto: fairly quick

lento: slow

rallentando (rall.): gradually getting slower

accelerando (accel.): gradually getting faster

a tempo: back to the original speed

crescendo (cresc.): gradually getting louder

diminuendo (dim.): gradually getting quieter

mezzo forte (mf): moderately loud

pianissimo (pp): very quiet

fortissimo (ff): very loud

legato: smoothly

staccato: detached

da capo (D.C.): repeat from the beginning

fine: the end

cantabile: in a singing style

dolce: sweetly

poco: a little

molto: very, much

forte (f): loud

piano (p): quiet

ritardando (ritard., rit.): gradually getting slower

decrescendo (decresc.): gradually getting quieter

Grade 2

presto: very fast

largo: slow and stately

vivace: lively, quick

dal segno (D.S.): repeat from the sign

più: more

meno: less

sempre: always

subito: suddenly

tenuto: held

grazioso: gracefully

con moto: with movement

ritenuto (rit.): held back

sforzando (sf): forced, with a sudden accent

mezzo piano (mp): moderately quiet

fortepiano (fp): loud, then immediately quiet

prestissimo: as fast as possible

ottava (8va): play an octave higher

da capo al fine: repeat from the beginning and stop at Fine

ma: but

non: not

troppo: too much

con: with

alla marcia: in the style of a march

Grade 3

ma non troppo: but not too much
espressivo: expressively
leggero: lightly
maestoso: majestically
sostenuto: sustained
tranquillo: calmly
giocoso: playful, merry
energico: with energy

Grade 4

assai: very
rubato: with some freedom of time
agitato: restless, worried
animato: animated, lively
scherzando: playfully, jokingly
con sordino: with a mute
senza: without
stringendo: gradually getting faster
allargando: broadening, getting slower
mesto: sad
pizzicato: plucked
arco: with the bow
una corda: press the soft pedal
lent: slow (French)
vite: quick (French)
modéré: at a moderate speed (French)

Grade 5

morendo: dying away
sotto voce: in a hushed voice, very quietly
langsam: slow (German)
schnell: fast (German)
mässig: at a moderate speed (German)
ruhig: peaceful (German)
lebhaft: lively (German)
ad libitum (ad lib.): at choice, freely
quasi: as if, almost
smorzando (smorz.): dying away in tone and speed
perdendosi: dying away, fading

Grade 6

divisi (div.): divided: the section splits onto separate notes
unisono (unis.): together again: all play the same notes
col legno: with the wood of the bow
sul ponticello: bow near the bridge
sul tasto: bow over the fingerboard
senza sordino: without a mute
tremolo: rapid repetition of a note, or quick alternation of two notes
a 2: both players play the same part
tutti: everyone plays
solo: one player alone
calando: getting softer and slower
brillante: brilliantly
con forza: with force
furioso: furiously
lacrimoso: tearfully, sadly
lusingando: coaxing, charmingly
nobilmente: nobly
piacevole: pleasantly

tempo primo: at the first speed
pesante: heavily
marcato: emphatic, accented
risoluto: boldly
semplice: simply
vivo: lively, quick
delicato: delicately
l'istesso tempo: at the same speed

larghetto: rather slow (less slow than largo)
con brio: with vigour, lively
tempo comodo: at a comfortable speed
deciso: decisively
affettuoso: tenderly
tre corde: release the soft pedal
simile: in the same way
come prima: as before
animé: animated, lively (French)
retenu: held back (French)
douce: sweet (French)
alla breve: two minim beats in a bar
amabile: lovable, pleasant
appassionato: passionately
misterioso: mysteriously
ritmico: rhythmically

attacca: go straight on to the next section
a niente: dying away to nothing
traurig: sad (German)
cantando: singing
con dolore: with grief
doloroso: sorrowfully
largamente: broadly
con spirito: with spirit
rinforzando (rf, rfz): reinforcing, with a sudden accent
sonoro: resonant
sforzato (sfz): forced, accented
tristamente: sadly

pomposo: pompously, grandly
strepitoso: noisily, boisterously
tempo giusto: in strict time
veloce: swiftly
vigoroso: vigorously
volante: flying, fast and light
incalzando: pressing on, getting quicker
slentando: getting slower
stretto: getting faster (pressing on)
tenerezza (con): with tenderness
lent et doux: slow and soft (French)
en dehors: bring out the melody (French)
cédez: slow down (French)
en mesure: in time (French)
sourdine: mute (French)
bewegt: with movement (German)
breit: broadly (German)
etwas: somewhat (German)
sehr: very (German)
zart: tenderly, delicately (German)
mit Dämpfer: with a mute (German)

Hauptstimme: the main part: bring it out (German)

sons étouffés: damped, muffled notes (French)

laissez vibrer: let it